

Incident handler's journal

Instructions

This journal records findings after completing activities and notes on what I learn about specific tools and concepts in the Google Cybersecurity Certificate course.

Date: September 30, 2026		Entry: #1
Description	Documenting a ransomware security incident at a small U.S. primary-care health clinic, delivered through a phishing email with a malicious attachment.	
Tool(s) used	None. This entry is based on a scenario review only. No cybersecurity tools were used for analysis.	
The 5 W's	Who caused the incident? An organized group of unethical hackers known to target organizations in the healthcare and transportation industries. What happened? Employees were locked out of their computers and could not access files such as medical records. A ransom note demanded a large payment in exchange for the decryption key, and business operations shut down. When did the incident occur? Tuesday morning at approximately 9:00 a.m. Where did the incident happen? At a small U.S. health care clinic that provides primary-care services, across employee computers and the company network. Why did the incident happen? Targeted phishing emails with a malicious attachment were sent to several employees. Once an attachment was downloaded, malware gave the attackers access and they deployed ransomware. The motive appears to be financial gain.	
Additional notes	The clinic could not reach critical patient data, which affects patient care as well as operations. Questions to consider: • What email filtering and attachment sandboxing could have stopped the phishing emails? • Were there recent offline backups so files could be restored without paying the ransom? • Is regular phishing awareness training in place for staff? • Was patient data accessed or stolen? If so, breach notification requirements (e.g., HIPAA) may apply. • Could network segmentation have limited how far the ransomware spread?	